essentials' concerning West Berlin: using all possible means, the US was willing to maintain the presence of the Western powers in Berlin, free access to the Western part of the city and to guarantee the freedom and viability of West Berlin. A few days later, Kennedy confided to Walt Rostow, Deputy Special Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs, that 'Khrushchev is losing East Germany'. He continued: 'He cannot let that happen. If East Germany goes, so will Poland and all of Eastern Europe. He will have to do something to stop the flow of refugees.'

From here on, any reservations that Khrushchev may have held about sealing off Berlin evaporated. During a two-hour conversation with Ulbricht on 1 August, he was informed about Honecker's plan to carve up Berlin.

In houses with exits into West Berlin, they will be walled up. In other places, barbed wire barriers will be erected. The barbed wire has already been delivered. It can all happen very quickly. It will be harder with transportation routes. We will then reconstruct the train platforms of the city trains [S-bahn] and underground trains [U-bahn] that go to West Berlin.

[6]

That same day, 1 August, Marshal Ivan Konev, as supreme commander of the Soviet Armed Forces in Germany (GSSD), approved Honecker's detailed plans. Then, on 5 August, the heads of state and party leaders of the Warsaw Pact met in Moscow and gave the go-ahead for the building of the Wall in Berlin. Khrushchev sermonised:

Let's look at it this way: if we don't take the needs of the GDR into account and don't make any sacrifices, then the German comrades won't be able to hold out […] By strengthening their